

service that you download or use is being run by a digital chaperone whose sole function is to see to your every need ... as long as you provide it with a generous tip in the form of your private data.

But is it really such a binary relationship?

Can you not enjoy a convenient existence without parting with your data? Silicon Valley giants would have you think that there is no other option. In fact, they'd go to extremes to put your mind at ease about sharing your data. Promises are made about data being completely anonymised, that only a minor portion of your data will be uploaded. Of course, data that is shared will only be used for internal purposes and for nothing else. Despite these promises, you will come across a news article about the very same company that had made these promises being sued for breach of trust. Or even worse, the company might get acquired by another entity who has no intention of honouring the promises that were made.

Then you might seek some respite in the legal system. There are several nations, states and groups of nations that have enacted strict laws regarding data retention and privacy. That's not going to deter the silicon valley giants as they'd simply hunt down a loophole in the system and exploit it. At this point, it wouldn't be prudent to limit all blame to "silicon valley giants". Technology firms all over the world are after some form of your data.

What we're trying to say is that you cannot leave it up to strangers when it comes to protecting your data. Especially in today's day and age where data collection happens all around you. It is entirely up to you to safeguard your data. Which is where this FastTrack comes handy. We get into all the different facets of privacy online. You'll learn what kind of data is most sought after, how companies track your movements online, which are the laws that attempt to protect your data, how you can make the most of said laws and what are the steps that you can take to safeguard your digital identity online.

We hope that this FastTrack helps you gain awareness about how companies extract your personal data and what you can do to stop that. Please write to editor@digit.in to let us know if this FastTrack helped you in any way. And as always, we're open to suggestions for future FastTracks. 